

NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 03

The Spectre of the Archaic World

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus $\approx$ 95 min read aloud
Scenes	12
Version	2026-09-23 · EN-GB dossier after P1

Unofficial non-commercial fan work. Text and commissioned artwork may not be redistributed or commercially reused without permission, subject to the rights of the respective underlying IP holders.

Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 03 — The Spectre of the Archaic World

Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

After Fuji, Red dreams the man in white and the feathered shadow. He refuses the Master Ball by measure, not by charity. The throne is amorphous. Kanto murmurs an old man in black. Johto: Lance–Rocket, sibling camouflage, the dignity of ordinary people. In Goldenrod, an Arbok recalls the ancient law.

Place in the arc

Due: white spectre already seen at Silph; Mewtwo; Coyote named by Oak at the League; Kanto → Johto crossing.

Paid: Red does not pretend to understand Mewtwo; Green cannot make amends; Oak admits why he did not congratulate; Gold/Richter recognises himself in Lance without becoming him.

Open: dark outline / Coyote; wild Houndoom; Arbok at Goldenrod; unrevealed past.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Red / Misty / Fuji	Nightmare; measured compassion; Master Ball refused
Green / Oak	Hollow throne; old man in black
Man in white	Silent reckoning; feathers; unnamed
Gold/Richter · Chris/Maria	Johto; discreet Dex; sibling camouflage
Lance (Team Rocket)	Executive — not the Champion
Mike / Bryan / Krise	Ordinary trainers; dignity without the League

Places (EN anchors)

Cerulean (Misty's room) · Fuji's lab · Oak's study · Kanto streets · Johto roads · Goldenrod.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Taken from the body. The narrative does not repeat them.

Heading	Note
The Coyote's Punishment	The bark: a wild Houndoom. A recycling of the original GSC / HGSS parameter: why Murkrow and Houndoom do not roam Johto, but Kanto.
New generation	Lance = ロケット団かんぶ ランス (Rocket executive). ≠ Champion ワタル.
Jealousy / ordinary people	Mini Skirt Krise = ミニスカート ユキ. Bird Keeper Bryan = とりつかい ヨシキ. Juggler Mike = ジャグラー マイク.
Speaker net	Gesture by A + speech by B: add “B went on:”. Otherwise infer the last named.
New generation	Pursuit power raised from 40 to 80, to intensify the risk of being read during a recall. Power also doubled against those who flee.
New generation	The female grunt is Lance's admirer at the Radio Tower in HGSS.
New generation	Levels — grunts: 12–14. Lance: Golbat 19–20; Weezing 22–23. Gold/Richter: Fearow 23.

BGM index — pieces

Scene	Piece	Span
Respective Compassion	She Who Mauls	00:00–00:24 · 02:10–02:30
Amorphous throne	Making Monsters	–00:44
Ordinary people	Dido's Lament	01:22–end
Hidden siblings	Too Heavy	late entry
Nightmares / Arbok	Eclipse (effect)	03:04–03:06

BGM index — traces

Scene	Trace
-------	-------

Graceful spectre (1)	Trace · EP07 S01 11:24–12:46 (not in full)
Waking	Trace · EP03 S02 04:00–04:54
Attempt at sleep	Trace · EP01 S02 08:00–08:17
Second nightmare	Trace · EP07 S01 11:24–12:46 (the rest)
Old man in black	Trace · EP05 S01 07:32–08:22 · EP01 S02 25:40–27:00
Jealousy / ordinary people	Trace · EP01 S02 19:53–20:33
Siblings	Trace · EP01 S01 or S02 16:46–17:00 (season to verify)
Primitive urge	Trace · EP03 S02 05:00–05:40

Order of scenes

1. The Graceful Spectre in White
2. Respective Compassion
3. The Amorphous, Heavy Throne
4. The Old Man in Black
5. The Old Man Coyote's Punishment
6. The New Generation
7. The Exotic Tradition
8. Two Are Already Rare
9. I Have No Need of Weak Pokémon
10. Jealousy towards Ordinary People
11. The Hidden Siblings
12. The Primitive Urge

The scenes are inserted here, without the scene-foot notes.

Scene – The graceful spectre in white

Red's nightmare (*immediately after the conversation with Dr Fuji – night, in the room lent by Misty*)

1. First nightmare (more vague)

BGM 'EP07 S01 11:24 12:46' (not in full)

Sleep engulfed him.

Red found himself in a vast, worn-out white space. A cold light bathed everything, with no visible source.

A few paces away, a man in a white suit stood. His hair was grey-blue, his features sharp. He had one hand in his trouser pocket, the other by his side. Behind him, far in the background, a **dark**, imposing **silhouette** loomed, its features and precise shape indistinguishable. From time to time, a black feather would detach itself from this shadow and fall slowly.

The man in white was looking at Red. His gaze was calm, ancient, almost administrative distance. There was no hostility in it. Only patient attention, as if he were observing something he had already seen happen many times before.

Red wanted to step back. He was unable to do so.

The man tilted his head ever so slightly. The movement was minuscule. Yet Red felt something close in within him.

A black feather fell between them.

The man in white stood still. He simply looked at him, whilst the feathers continued to fall one by one into the white silence.

2. Red awakens (once only)

BGM 'EP03 S02 04:00–04:54'

Red woke with a start, gasping for breath.

The room was dark. He sat on the bed for a long time, his forehead in his hands. He wasn't trembling. He simply had the very distinct feeling that he'd been watched whilst he slept.

He went down to the kitchen. Misty was already there.

Red sat down opposite her. It took him a long while before he spoke.

"I think I've attracted something," he said at last, in a low voice. "Not an ordinary threat. Something that's watching. I sensed it whilst I was asleep. As if someone had already spotted me... because of what I've done."

Misty looked at him without trying to reassure him straight away.

"Are you talking about anyone in particular?" she asked softly.

Red shook his head.

"I don't know who it is. But he's there. And he doesn't seem to be in any hurry. That's what bothers me the most."

Misty placed her hand next to his on the table:

"You shouldn't stay alone with this."

Red did not reply. He returned to his room.

3. Trying to sleep

BGM 'EP01 S02 08:00–08:17'

He lay back down. The room was silent. He closed his eyes.

Sleep returned, but it was fragile, like an icy surface.

4. Second nightmare (clearer and more oppressive) – Ends within the nightmare

BGM 'EP07 S01 11:24–12:46' (the rest)

This time, the white space was clearer.

The man in the white suit was standing less than three paces away. His face was clearer to see: regular features, a faint scar near his right eye, a clear, cold gaze. His right hand was still in his pocket. His left hand hung by his side, fingers slightly splayed.

Behind him, the **dark outline** was slightly more visible than before, though still blurred. You could make out an imposing figure, whose shoulders seemed to bear an ancient weight. From time to time, a black feather would detach itself from this shadow and fall slowly.

The man in white did not speak.

He merely looked at Red.

His gaze was more direct than the first time. More intense. There was no longer any formal distance. There was a kind of silent acknowledgement: *you have already touched what should not have been touched*.

Red wanted to look away. He was unable to.

The man in white took **a step forward**. The movement was slow, measured, almost languid. He stopped again. His gaze did not leave Red for a single second.

Another black feather fell. It landed between them.

The man tilted his head ever so slightly. That was his only gesture.

Behind him, the dark silhouette seemed, for a moment, **to draw slightly closer**, as if the shadow itself had bowed towards Red. The black feathers began to fall in greater numbers, swirling slowly through the white air.

The man in white remained perfectly still. He did not step back. He did not speak. He simply stared at Red, whilst the black feathers continued to fall, in ever-greater numbers, gradually darkening the white space.

Red felt his sleep breaking... but he did not wake up.

The image remained frozen on the man in white, standing there in silence, with the dark silhouette behind him and the black feathers falling endlessly.

'Eclipse' effect 03:04–03:06

End of scene

Scene – Respective compassion

Twilight in the laboratory

The light was fading behind the tall shutters. It now cast nothing but long, coppery streaks across the workbenches and empty vats. The air smelled of warm paper, ozone and over-brewed black tea. From the discreet speakers, a deep, tense piece of music rose up, almost without a melody.

Fuji poured a sip into his cup. His fingers hesitated slightly on the porcelain.

‘...Thank you for agreeing to this request,’ he said in a low voice.

Red didn’t look up straight away. He was leafing through the files Fuji had handed him, their thick pages annotated by hand. He turned the pages with methodical slowness.

BGM ‘She Who Mauls’ 00:00 → 00:24:

The music grew slightly richer. A line of low strings rose, then fell.

Red paused on a page.

‘Mewtwo has a biological impairment linked to its Psychic-type. It almost exclusively learns attack moves of this type.’

Fuji nodded:

“Indeed. If that is of any use to you.”

Red turned another page. The paper rustled.

‘...I have a question, if I may,’ said Red. ‘Why did you entrust me with this mission?’

Fuji set down his cup. The slight clink against the metal of the workbench was louder than it should have been.

“To take responsibility for my mistakes... momentary ones, so to speak. And to prevent further victims.”

Red finally looked up. His gaze was calm, almost neutral.

“That is conceivable. But... what of this Pokémon’s feelings?”

Fuji turned his head slightly away.

"That's a secondary consideration. It's supposed to have suffered greatly."

Red closed the folder. The sound of cardboard striking metal was sharp and final.

"I cannot truly fathom its anguish."

Fuji looked at him, surprised:

"Why do you say that?"

Red remained silent for a moment. His fingers rested on the closed folder.

"...I'm not an artificial being like it. So I don't pretend."

Fuji didn't reply straight away. His fingers tightened imperceptibly around the cup.

"So be it," said Fuji at last. "But... are you sure you don't want to use the Master Ball?"

Red did not smile; his expression remained perfectly composed.

"...Do you really think that would ease its suffering? Or his resentment towards humans?"

Fuji lowered his gaze to the table.

"No. I'm only mentioning it for your own safety. And that of your Pokémon."

Red opened the folder again, but without leafing through it. He simply rested his hand on it.

"I've studied your data. This Pokémon is very strong, that's for sure... but no more of a problem than the entire team of someone I've already defeated. The risk is calculated. A viable approach presents itself to me."

Fuji regarded him in silence for a long time. The music coming from the speakers seemed to have faded to a softer hum.

"It's... paradoxical," he murmured. "I approached you thinking about your motivation for challenging the League. And yet, you're so..."

"Indolent? Too calculating?"

Fuji shook his head slowly.

"...You've outstripped what people usually imagine. Or you're more pragmatic still than some men of science."

Red lowered his voice slightly. It was not gentleness, but precision.

"I have accepted your request. But I have less grounds for taking action against it than I did when I faced Green. And from what you've written... this Pokémon hasn't done anything irreparable yet. Perhaps it still deserves a chance. Not out of kindness. Simply because, for the time being, there is still no justification for taking away every possibility it has."

Fuji recoiled ever so slightly.

"You speak as though you were accepting it out of mere kindness... or charity."

Red looked at him frankly.

“Not at all. I sense its sadness. As a human, I’m probably best placed to see it. But I can’t truly understand it. Not entirely. The gap between an artificial Pokémon and a human being is too great. So the solutions must remain pragmatic. Precise. Measured. I refuse to feign an understanding that I do not have. That would be indecent towards him. It would be leading it to believe it is understood, when in fact it isn’t.”

BGM ‘She Who Mauls’ 02:10 → 02:30

A long silence followed. The music had taken on a more melancholic tone.

Red added, in a lower voice:

“Your reports also mention that it is capable of telepathy. In that case... sincere words might perhaps work. But it would be better if its family could intervene. If Mew deigns to intercede. That would be... fairer. More human.”

He did not say ‘our favour’, as if it still concerned someone other than himself.

Fuji stood motionless. His eyes remained fixed on the surface of the table, where the twilight cast a thin, trembling line. He had sensed something — a form, an intuition as yet unnamed — but he already knew it would take him years before he could even begin to put it into words. For now there was only this vague unease, this sense that something important had just happened, though he did not yet know which way the scales were tipping.

Red closed the folder one last time.

Outside, night had almost fallen.

End of scene

Scene – The amorphous, heavy crown

Professor Oak’s office inside the laboratory

BGM ‘Making Monsters’ 00:00 – 00:44

Twilight streamed in at an angle through the tall window, casting the desk into patches of shadow and a dull coppery glow. The shelves seemed to have sagged under their own weight, as if they had absorbed too many silences over the years. On the desk, a lamp with a green shade cast a dim glow that failed to illuminate much of anything. From the discreet speakers, a deep, tense piece of music rose up, almost without melody.

Green was sitting behind his grandfather’s desk. He hadn’t taken off his jacket. His hands lay flat on the wood, his fingers slightly spread, as if he were trying to feel something stable beneath him. Red was standing a little way back, leaning against the edge of a bookcase. He still had his bag slung over his shoulder.

Green spoke first, in a voice he meant to sound light-hearted, but which came across as a little too forced.

‘So, did you manage to catch that Pokémon? Unbelievable... It’s as if you have no limits. As if you don’t care about life at all.’

Red looked down for a moment at the worn carpet, then looked up again.

"Yes, I do value it. If I didn't, I wouldn't have taken on this sort of assignment."

Green nodded, a little too quickly. He searched for the right words.

"Even without that... my grandfather describes you more as a philanthropist."

Red let a moment of silence pass. When he replied, his voice remained calm and slightly weary.

"You could describe me that way. But I'm not really cut out for self-sacrifice."

Green looked down at his hands. He seemed to be searching for something to say that might have sounded right, without really managing it.

"...Why did you agree to it, then?"

Red turned his head slightly towards the window. The twilight cast a thin line across his cheek.

"That Pokémon reminded me of someone. a fellow obsessed with the idea of being the strongest. I thought that if I could contain that sort of person in check... I thought that, out of my debt to Oak, I could handle the strongest of the Pokémon. A realistic assessment."

Green looked down at his hands.

'So if it weren't for my grandfather, you wouldn't have lifted a finger?'

Red shrugged slightly. It was neither indifference nor coldness. Just a kind of honest weariness.

"Yes, probably. But I'd have been in far less of a hurry. And far less sure it was a good idea."

Another silence fell. Green kept his eyes downcast. He finally asked the question he'd been holding back for a while, in a lower voice:

'And you... how do you feel, now that you're the one wearing the crown?'

Red did not answer straight away. When he spoke, it was in a low, almost detached voice:

"I used to care about it. Passively. One day, they put it on me. And I discovered that it was... amorphous. Very hollow. But heavy. So heavy that I can no longer really tell who I am underneath it."

He had spoken without raising his voice. Without irony. Just a weary observation.

Green didn't move. The words had struck him more deeply than he'd expected, but he didn't know what to make of them. He'd wanted to make amends to Red. He'd wanted to find the right words, the gestures that might have eased the burden somewhat. But all he'd managed to do was sit there in that cosy office, searching for an apology that would have had no tangible effect.

Red sat up slightly.

"I should go."

Green nodded without standing up. He couldn't think of anything to say that would have made sense. He kept his hands resting on the wood, his fingers slightly spread, as if he were still trying to cling to something solid.

Red left without another word. The door closed softly behind him.

In the office, Green remained alone, motionless, whilst the deep music continued to play through the speakers, as if it were accompanying, without comment, the slow collapse of something that no longer had the strength to stand up again.

End of scene

Scene – The old man in black

The Twilight of Kanto

BGM 'EP05 S01 07:32 08:22'

Daylight was fading from the streets of Kanto. Shadows stretched like gashes between the buildings, and the evening breeze stirred up fine dust from the still-warm pavements. Red walked aimlessly. He had defeated Giovanni. He had defeated Green. He had captured Mewtwo. Three threats he considered to be major. And yet evil had not retreated.

Near a small square, an old man was speaking in a low voice to a child who refused to go home. His voice was flat and worn.

'...otherwise he'll come and get you tonight. He's always dressed in black. And when he finds you, he doesn't hurt you. He just stays there, by your bedside, until morning. And the next day, you carry on living... but you feel that something inside you is missing. As if part of your body no longer really belongs to you. You move, you speak, but there's a place, somewhere, that doesn't quite respond anymore.'

The child squeezed his mother's hand without replying. The old man didn't look up.

A little further on, in front of a closed shop, two young people were walking and talking in hushed tones.

'My grandmother used to say she'd seen him once, when she was young. She'd gone too far with something she shouldn't have done. She said he'd watched her for nights on end. Not to punish her. Just to watch her. And every time she woke up, she felt as though part of her face wasn't quite in the right place. As if the skin no longer fitted properly over the bones. She'd spend hours in front of the mirror trying to put things back the way they were. But it never quite went back to normal.'

Red walked past them. The words lingered.

In a small café whose door had been left ajar, a middle-aged man was talking to the owner, both their heads bent over the counter.

'...my uncle swore he'd seen him near the old warehouses. An old man dressed all in black, walking without making a sound. Ever since that day, he couldn't look at himself in a mirror without feeling as though someone else was staring back at him from the other side. He said the old man didn't take life. He took the ability to recognise oneself. And once it was gone, you could never fully get it back. He felt as though his own reflection was judging him.'

Red carried on walking. The sky was turning a murky purple. He then remembered the snippets he'd overheard as a child, which he'd deliberately pushed to the back of his mind. Fragmentary stories, told at different stages of his life. An old man dressed in black. A spectre who visited the dreams of

refractory children. A presence that preyed upon those who defied an order that was far too ancient. He'd always believed it was just folklore.

BGM 'EP01 S02 25:40 27:00'

Tonight, those fragments no longer seemed so distant to him.

He stopped at a street corner. Fear was no longer just an idea. It had begun to take shape, cold and precise, somewhere beneath his ribs. He had overcome three major threats. And yet, something ancient, subtle, almost invisible, continued to exist. And he now remembered that Professor Oak, years earlier, had spoken to him about this thing. Not as a legend. But as a reality best left unchallenged.

Red changed direction. This time, he walked faster.

Oak's laboratory

The light in the laboratory was almost out. Only a lamp with a green shade cast a faint glow over the desk. Oak was sitting with his hands clasped in front of him. When Red entered, he did not stand up. He merely seemed to stiffen, as if a heavy burden had just been placed upon his shoulders. His shoulders tensed with visible force.

Red stood by the door for a moment before speaking.

'May I ask you something, Professor?'

Oak looked up. His face was calm, but his hands remained clasped, the knuckles white with the pressure. There was a long silence. Too long. His shoulders were now noticeably hunched, and a slight tension could be seen in the nape of his neck, as if he were holding his breath.

Red took a step forward.

"Do you know a story... about an old man in black?"

Oak lowered his head slightly. He did not reply straight away. His fingers clenched even tighter together, until his knuckles turned almost white. He averted his gaze towards the desk, as if trying to make himself smaller. When he finally spoke, his voice was low, cautious, almost weary.

"...You'll find better answers by asking people more qualified than me. But..." He broke off. He kept his eyes downcast for a moment longer. A visible tension was now evident in the nape of his neck.

"That's why I didn't manage to congratulate you on your League victory."

He kept his eyes downcast for a moment longer, his hands still clasped, his shoulders hunched, and a very slight tremor was now visible in his fingers. He finally looked up at Red. There was no obvious fear in his gaze, only a kind of long-standing reluctance, mingled with a kindness that seemed almost powerless. He made no attempt to say more that evening. And Red, for the time being, made no attempt to press him.

Outside, night had fallen completely.

End of scene

Scene – The Old Man Coyote's Punishment

On the outskirts of Celadon City (twilight)

Red walked slowly along the path that ran alongside the edge of the forest. The sky was turning a dull mauve, and the first stars were beginning to appear. He had taken off his headband; the cool wind ruffled his hair with an almost irritating indifference.

He had won. Against Green. Against Giovanni. He had done what was expected of him. Yet something felt wrong. Not with the victory itself, but with what remained afterwards. As if defeating the visible faces of evil had not been enough to drive back the shadow they cast.

He leaned back against a thick tree, arms crossed, and let his gaze drift into the darkening sky. He was thinking of Misty. Of the distance he'd put between them, not out of coldness, but because he'd believed it necessary to bear alone the burden of what he'd become. That certainty already seemed less solid to him than before.

A very slight, almost imperceptible movement caught his attention in the branches above him. A black feather fell, twirling as it went, and came to rest a few paces from his feet.

BGM: 'What Power Art Thou' EP04 S02 09:47-12:17

Red looked up.

A dozen or so black birds were perched on the twigs. They hardly moved at all. Their feathers were a deep, almost glossy black, and their eyes a murky red, too deep to reflect anything but the present. It was as if they were looking right through him, towards something ancient.

Red did not recognise them. They were neither Pidgey nor Spearow. There was nothing natural about their presence. They stared at him without any apparent hostility. Their gazes were almost nonchalant, almost empty. And yet, Red felt an unpleasant tightness rising in his chest.

It was not the fear of dying. It was something else. As if these birds carried within them the memory of all those who, over the centuries, had been stifled by an order that was no longer named, but which had never truly disappeared.

They were staring at him. Their gazes were fixed, lifeless, almost nonchalant. Devoid of any expression. And it was precisely this absence that made their presence unbearable. There was neither hatred nor curiosity in those eyes. Only a kind of ancient, mechanical attention that seemed to have been observing for a very long time.

One of them turned its head slightly. The movement was minuscule, almost insignificant. Yet Red felt something stir within him. As if that simple shift of the eyes had revealed a greater impulse: an ancient, obstinate will that refused to fade away. That sought to endure, come what may. Whatever atrocity had to be committed. Whatever subterfuge had to be employed.

Another Murkrow shifted its talons slightly on the branch. The wood creaked faintly. The bird then folded one wing with deliberate slowness, almost lazily. These tiny gestures, performed without any visible emotion, seemed more unsettling than if they had been aggressive.

The movement was minimal. Almost sluggish. Yet Red had the feeling he'd just understood something he shouldn't have understood.

BGM: 'My Sister' (from 01:11)

Behind those birds, there was a presence. Not a direct threat, but a cold, ancient watchfulness. Someone — or something — was using them to observe. And that thing didn't need to force them. They watched because it was their nature.

Red suddenly sensed that the ground beneath his feet was less stable than he'd thought. He'd defeated Giovanni. He'd defeated Green. But he realised, in a flash of icy clarity, that he hadn't touched that. That it might not even have been grazed.

BGM: 'My Sister' 01:54–

One of the Murkrow spread its wings slightly, as if to take flight. Red tensed.

The bird did not attack him. It merely took off, circled slowly and widely above him, then returned to perch further away. It was not stalking Red, but flying about the vicinity, as if hunting prey in a haphazard and delirious manner, with a demonic air. As if it had merely been testing him.

Red did not hesitate. He turned on his heel and walked away at a brisk, almost frantic pace towards the town. He was not running yet, but his body had already started moving before his reason could stop him.

His breathing had already become short and irregular. He did not fully understand why he was fleeing, but his body had reacted before his mind could. Every step felt too slow. He had the feeling that if he stayed a second longer, something would find him.

Behind him, in the darkening sky, a distant, deep and mournful bark tore through the silence of twilight.

Red felt his stomach clench violently.

Background music: 'My Sister' 02:08–

The barking repeated once, then twice. Each time, his fear rose a notch. It was no longer a vague sense of unease. It was a brutal certainty: something was hunting him. Something that could track him down even from a distance. Something that, if it found him, would not hesitate to kill him.

He picked up the pace. His legs were now moving almost of their own accord. His breathing had become ragged and loud. He felt as though his heart was pounding too loudly in his chest, as if it might give away his position. A cold wave of nausea rose in his throat. He did not know exactly what was chasing him, but he sensed, deep down, that if he were caught, he would not simply be watched.

He would be eliminated.

Red did not look behind him. He was now running, breathless, his muscles tense, with the very clear and very primal sensation that something ancient, patient and merciless was stalking him. And that shadow, he could now sense, had not gone away.

Part 2 – Lance (Champion) & Green

Location: Pokémon League (for Lance) / Professor Oak's Laboratory (for Green) **Time:** Dusk **BGM:** *Making Monsters* – (up to 00:44)

Lance stood alone on the League's terrace, his arms folded across the railing. The evening breeze made his coat flutter slightly. Below, the city lights were beginning to come on.

He was thinking back on the battle. Red had beaten Green, yes. But Lance had seen something else in his eyes that day. No triumph. Not even satisfaction. Just a kind of weariness, almost resignation. And Lance had not said a word. He had applauded along with the others, as one does when a new champion is crowned.

He clenched his fingers slightly around the banister.

He had not acted. Not because he had failed to notice, but because he had chosen not to intervene. It had been simpler that way. Cleaner. Now Red had stepped down, and Lance was left with this unpleasant truth: he had let a boy bear alone a burden he perhaps should never have had to bear.

He stood motionless for a long while, his gaze lost on the darkening horizon.

Green was sitting at the lab desk, his elbows resting on the wood, his hands clasped in front of his mouth. The computer screen was still on, but he wasn't looking at it any more.

He'd replayed the fight over and over in his head. Red had won. Green knew that better than anyone. But he'd also seen, at the moment of defeat, that Red wasn't really enjoying the victory. Not as he would have done in the past.

Green slowly lowered his hands.

He felt guilty. Not just for having lost. But for realising, too late, that Red might never really have wanted to become what everyone expected of him. And Green, who had always regarded him as a rival, had done nothing to lighten that burden. Quite the opposite.

He stood motionless for a long time, staring blankly at the desk. His remorse was heavier than Lance's. More personal. Harder to bear.

Part 3 – Misty

Location: Misty's house (Cerulean City) **Time:** Dusk **BGM:** *Always* – Nocturne (up to 00:24)

Misty was standing in the kitchen, one hand resting on the edge of the table. The note was still there, lying by the window. She'd already read it several times. The words hadn't changed.

'I don't regret stopping Green. But if I'd known that the evil wouldn't disappear with him, I would have done things differently. I should have stayed with those who really mattered to me. Forgive me.'

She stood motionless for a moment. The sky outside the window was turning dark blue. She wanted to cry. She could feel it – that pressure behind her eyes. But the tears wouldn't come. They were stuck somewhere, as if her body refused to grant her that relief.

She lowered her head slightly.

She'd been there. Not all the time, but often enough. And she hadn't realised just how much Red had withdrawn. Or rather, she'd seen it, but she'd chosen to believe it was temporary. That it would pass once he'd done what was expected of him.

She gently rested her fingers on the edge of the note, without picking it up again.

Red had made his choice. He had given up. And there was nothing she could do to change that. She no longer had the right to beg him to stay, nor to blame him for leaving. All she could do was accept that he had decided on his own.

Misty stood there for a long time, motionless, her gaze fixed on the paper. Twilight continued to fall outside, and the house was silent.

End of scene

Scene – The New Generation

Outside the Slowpoke Well (Evening). 2–3 years later in Johto

BGM 'Vive la révolution'

Night had already swallowed up the last vestiges of daylight when a boy stopped at the edge of the clearing. The air smelled of damp earth and rotting leaves. Before him, Kurt was cornered against the old well, surrounded by half a dozen figures in black uniforms. His hands were clenched into fists at his sides, his knuckles white. He lowered his head slightly, as if trying to hold back a pang of remorse rising in his throat. His impulsiveness had led him there, and he knew it. Their Pokémon—nervous Rattata, flapping Zubat, smoking Koffing and a coiled Ekans—formed an irregular circle, more noisy than menacing. They showed neither hatred nor haste. Their movements were time-honoured, almost ritualised: a measured step, a hand rising slowly to give a silent command, Pokémon taking their places without undue haste. It was a well-worn routine, passed down rather than conceived.

BGM 'Vive la révolution' 00:39

The boy said nothing. He shifted his hunting crop from one hand to the other, the worn leather rustling softly against his glove. His gaze swept once over the group, then settled on Fearow, already hovering above him. A very slight movement of his right wrist — almost imperceptible, a mere release of the tension in the leather — was enough.

Fearow, already flying above the clearing, changed direction without a cry. It was then that a piercing scream rent the air.

Fearow shot out of the trees like a projectile. It did not merely swoop down on the group: it executed a violent initial dive, clawing at an Ekans before immediately soaring back into the air with *Aerial Ace*. The Grunts and their Pokémon hesitated for a moment.

The bird of prey dove down, not straight at the Grunts, but at an angle, skimming close to the ground. Its eyes, in the dim light, changed. It was no longer the sharp gaze of a bird of prey; it was something older, more animalistic—*Leer*. The Grunts's Pokémon sensed it even before their Trainers could react. A Rattata took a step back, its lips curled in a growl that died in its throat. A Zubat lost the rhythm of

its flapping. The Ekans, which had been about to spit, froze for a fraction of a second, head bowed, as if an invisible weight were pressing down on the nape of its neck.

It was in that moment of hesitation that Gold/Richter stepped forward.

The Hunting Crop whistled once, a short, precise blast. It did not strike the Pokémon directly: it hit the ground just in front of a Koffing that had strayed too far forward. The smoke the creature had begun to spew dispersed in a circular motion, as if the air itself had been split — *Smoke Screen*. Fearow, already back in the air, flapped its wings in a peculiar manner—a broad, almost lazy flap—and the cloud of smoke emitted by Fearow suddenly spread towards the minions instead of protecting them: *Mirror Move*. They coughed, blinked and lost their bearings.

One of the Rattata, quicker than the others, attempted a low charge, Quick Attack. Fearow watched it for half a second, then replicated the movement in mid-air: a short, brutal dive that followed exactly the same line of attack, *Mirror Move*. The Rattata was hurled backwards before it even realised what had struck it.

Gold/Richter continued to advance, slowly. The Hunting Crop kept spinning, sometimes very close to the ground, sometimes at chest height. It was not hesitation; it was **reading the situation**. He was waiting for someone to make a mistake in their stance, a glance that lingered too long, a misplacement of weight.

Gold/Richter did not shout. He did not call out anything. He advanced, the Hunting Crop tracing tight arcs, controlling the space around him as if drawing an invisible boundary. When a Grunt tried to recall his Pokémon — a Zubat flapping its wings in panic — Fearow dived without being asked. The strike was clean, almost surgical: *Pursuit*. The Zubat vanished into its Poké Ball with a strangled cry. Among the trees, some twenty metres away, a figure watched.

Lance stood motionless. His gaze, through the branches, followed every movement with cold, unbroken attention. He was not seeking to intervene. He was assessing the situation. His Golbat, perched on a low branch, made not a sound. Lance noted the way Gold/Richter gave no visible commands, the way Fearow responded to almost invisible signals. He also noted the restraint: the boy had not sought to harm the Grunt who had tried to throw his Ball. It was calculated precision, not gratuitous savagery.

Ekans, having snapped out of its stupor, straightened up and aimed directly at Gold/Richter. This time, the boy did not move the Crop. He merely stared at the snake, his eyelids slightly lowered. His body remained perfectly still, except for the hunting Crop, which continued its slow circular motion. He simply turned his head, very slightly, towards the snake. Fearow, which had been hovering, changed its angle in a fraction of a second. Its shadow fell across the Ekans. The snake hesitated once more — just long enough for the hunting Crop to wrap itself round its body and hurl it violently against the trunk of a tree. There was a dull thud. The Ekans did not get back up.

BGM 'Vive la révolution' 01:37

The Grunts were beginning to retreat. Their orders were conflicting. Another tried to throw a new Poké Ball. Gold/Richter did not even look at him. He made a tiny flick of his wrist. The Poké Ball was flung to the ground before it had even left his hand. It rolled across the grass without opening. The Grunt stepped back, startled, but unharmed.

Gold/Richter had not intended to harm him; he had merely calculated that he could not permit further reinforcements to arrive.

Fearow struck again, this time at a Rattata trying to escape. The blow was harder.

Fearow dived without Gold/Richter needing to tell it to. The blow was harder than the previous ones: *Pursuit*. The little Pokémon rolled over and lay still.

BGM 'Vive la révolution' – 02:00

Then, after the final move, silence fell abruptly.

Gold/Richter paused. He drew a single, calm breath. He made a slow, precise flick of his right wrist, then his left. The hunting crop coiled up in three fluid turns and slid into his belt with a sharp, decisive movement. The leather glistened with moisture.

Fearow returned and perched on a low branch, just above him. Its eyes had regained their usual expression, but there was still a hint of something animalistic lingering in the corner of its gaze.

Gold/Richter did not let his guard down.

He slowly turned his head, scanning every corner of the clearing, the bushes, the shadows between the trees. His face remained impassive. Only his eyes moved, methodically, almost slowly. Fearow, perched above him, did the same. The bird of prey turned its head to one side, then the other, scrutinising the slightest movements in the grass and the branches.

Then, almost without moving the rest of his body, Gold/Richter cast a very brief, almost motionless glance towards the remaining Grunts. It was not a look of triumph. It was a simple observation. A silent warning.

One of them, a man in his thirties, had hands that were trembling slightly. Another clutched his empty Poké Ball as if it could still protect him. Their surviving Pokémon huddled behind them, crouched low, their eyes downcast. They had understood. Resistance would serve no purpose now. Defeat was sealed.

Gold/Richter and Fearow remained perfectly still. They showed neither triumph nor nonchalance. Only a **cold, unrelenting vigilance**. The boy knew that victory was only assured once the last opponent had given up, or had been neutralised. As long as there remained even the slightest possibility of escape, he would not let his guard down.

The Grunts could read it in that glance which had brushed over them without lingering. They knew he had seen them all. That he had gauged their fear. And that he drew no visible satisfaction from it. Only the calm certainty that none of them would escape.

One of the men took a step back, then another. His Pokémon, a wounded Koffing, began to back away with him, emitting a faint, ragged hiss. Another Grunt lowered his head, his shoulders slumped. The retreat was not yet a chaotic free-for-all. It was something slower, heavier: the gradual and inexorable realisation of their powerlessness.

Gold/Richter said nothing. He simply continued to watch, his right hand slightly open near his belt, ready to grasp the hunting crop again if necessary. Fearow, hovering above him, barely blinked.

The clearing had become very quiet.

BGM 'Vive la révolution' 02:29—the end

A leaf fell. The shadow stirred.

From the treetops, Lance's Golbat swooped down without a cry. Not a single dive. Two lines: one towards Fearow, the other towards the boy's back. Split them. Gain the upper hand in the gap. The ambush to bridge the gap.

Fearow did not wait for the order. A diagonal attack, *Aerial Ace*. The Golbat's wing was hit. The second line, however, was still holding.

Gold/Richter looked up.

No grand gesture. His arm, sharp, as if swatting a fly. The Hunting Crop unfurled. The tip struck the other wing, just as the jaws snapped shut. An almost metallic clang. Not enough to bring it down.

Golbat held its ground. A single flap of its wings. It assessed the situation: Fearow above, the Crop already back in hand, no more angle to cut through the pair. There was no advantage to be gained. The collusion between Fearow and Gold/Richter was confirmed. Sacrificing itself after that was no longer a calculated move.

BGM: 'Vampire Messiah' (00:00–00:44)

Golbat shifted off to the side, with phlegmatic ease. Not with its back turned, out of wariness of Fearow's Pursuit. Nor giving away any opportunity to invade its space for free. No second charge. A single flap, towards the woods. Enough to show *where*.

Lance didn't flinch. Motionless in the shadows. Eyes half-closed. He was still watching.

Fearow turned its head towards the Golbat. The latter did not return. It was moving on; weariness was evident only in the irregularity of a single flap. Fearow did not dive. It stared at the shadow.

Gold/Richter did not look at the Pokémon. His eyes were on the trees. A glance at Kurt—alive—then at the man.

Fearow flew silently away behind him.

Lance took a step forward, beneath the moon. His expression was indecipherable. Gold/Richter glanced at Kurt — who was alive — then turned his attention back to the man.

Reinforcements at this level were already accounted for. No need to keep an eye on the rest.

Lance watched for a second. A quiet sigh.

"Well... what a nuisance."

His voice was calm, almost detached.

"I'll have to report this to Apollo."

Gold/Richter narrowed his eyes slightly.

"Apollo?"

BGM 'Work of the Devil'

"You'll meet him eventually... if you carry on meddling in our affairs."

Gold/Richter watched Lance in silence. The man seemed neither hurried nor worried. His calmness was almost unsettling.

"Why go to all this trouble? You do not even seem to really believe in it."

"Because it is our role. Nothing more."

'Your role? So you have no purpose at all?'

"Others want to free the Pokémon or remake the world. We're content just to carry on. That's hard enough as it is."

Lance paused, then added in a colder tone:

"The absence of grand ambition... that may well be the only thing that sets us apart. It allows us to remain effective."

"Effective at terrorising Pokémon and civilians?" Gold/Richter was struck by a thought that seemed like heresy.

"Let us simply say we are craftsmen. Like that old man over there. It is just that our trade is different."

Gold/Richter clenched his jaw. Comparing Lance to Kurt seemed almost obscene to him. One crafted Poké Balls with respect. The other reduced his 'trade' to plunder and blackmail.

'This discussion is over. You're coming with me, and—'

Gold/Richter broke off.

Lance had discreetly produced a black and purple Poké Ball. Gold/Richter recognised it immediately.

"...A Weezing."

"Quite right."

Lance held the Poké Ball without throwing it, in an almost nonchalant gesture.

"I propose a simple arrangement. You let us go. In exchange, I shall not need to resort to... excessive measures," Lance negotiated.

Gold/Richter remained silent, his eyes fixed on the Poké Ball.

"Would you threaten to blow everything up?"

"No," Lance denied. "I hate unnecessary complications. Capturing you or forcing you to surrender would mean I'd have to keep an eye on you... and I have no desire to deal with that sort of variable."

A henchwoman standing a little way back let out a nervous little laugh. Gold/Richter felt as though he'd been insulted:

"How dare you exploit a situation like this..."

"Sorry... Mr Lance has a reputation for being cruel. But we didn't expect it to be... such calculated cruelty. It's... surprising," said the henchwoman.

"I've never claimed otherwise."

Gold/Richter glanced at Kurt and the injured Pokémon. His fist slowly clenched.

Finally, he slammed his open palm violently onto the ground, his expression dark:

"...Go. But next time, I won't give you that chance."

"I'll bear that in mind," replied Lance.

Lance replaced the Poké Ball without another word. The Grunts began to back away cautiously. Lance, for his part, walked away calmly, as if this confrontation had been nothing more than a formality.

End of scene

Scene – The Exotic Tradition

Kurt's residence

BGM 'EP06 S02 12:40–15:30'

The room smelled of dry wood, warm metal and a faint whiff of tea that had been left to steep a little too long. An oil lamp cast a flickering yellow light onto the workbench, which was cluttered with tools. Kurt worked unhurriedly, yet without any slackness. His hammer blows fell with a heavy regularity, as if he were trying to subdue the material rather than listen to it. From time to time, he would mutter something unintelligible through clenched teeth, then resume his work.

Gold/Richter was sitting at the table. The cup of tea Kurt had served him was still steaming, untouched. He stared at the surface of the liquid without really seeing it. His mind kept returning to Lance's blackmail, to that explosion he'd been unable to prevent. Even his victory left a bitter taste in his mouth.

Kurt set his hammer down more roughly than necessary. The sound echoed through the room.

'Doesn't that whet your thirst?' he asked in a slightly harsh voice, without turning round straight away.

Gold/Richter blinked, snapped out of his thoughts.

"Ah... no. Thanks anyway."

Kurt wiped his hands on a greasy cloth, then finally turned to face him. His face was weathered, his eyebrows bushy, and his gaze retained a certain sharpness despite his age.

"My apologies for ruining your tasting... because of my carelessness, which has tarnished your victory."

There was a hint of annoyance in his voice, as if he were struggling to utter those words.

Gold/Richter shook his head slightly.

"It doesn't really bother me. That's a different matter."

Kurt stared at him for a moment, then let out a small, dry laugh, almost ironic.

"Oh... Someone like you, who's just been in a fight himself, isn't all that... combative. Interesting."

Gold/Richter felt the colour rise to his cheeks. He lowered his eyes and searched for the right words.

"Explain to me... that hasty action? Those bandits were from Kanto. That lesson could have cost you your life."

He took a sip of tea, more to compose himself than out of thirst.

Kurt picked up his hammer again. The next blow was sharper, almost aggressive.

‘The town is at the mercy of the rain. And the Slowpokes bring it to us. Without them, the drought would have been worse... and the land would have become more barren. ’

He struck once more, then stopped short.

“One can form a bond with them without a ball. Few do. Most need that threshold to become familiar with them. We capture. Not to enslave. To understand.”

The hammer remained raised, for a moment too long.

“This revulsion... it stems from the craft. To forge the instrument is to know what one must not do with it. The blasphemy against life was the most unforgivable. We, in Johto, do not tolerate that easily.”

He set the tool down somewhat stiffly, as if he were struggling to admit that last part.

“But I underestimated their skills... and overestimated my own. Ironically, a passion for tradition can cloud our judgement. And enthusiasm for culture can make us frivolous when we lose sight of prudence. I, too, am no exception.”

He looked up at Gold/Richter. His voice was lower, a little heavier.

“That is why I thank Ho-Oh and Lugia for sending you to me. Even if I don’t like having to admit it.”

Gold/Richter clenched his jaw slightly.

‘I’m afraid I can take little credit for any of this.’

Kurt looked at him for a long time. His gaze lingered on the young man’s outfit, then on the hunting crop resting against the table. There was a kind of curiosity in his eyes, mixed with a touch of local pride.

“Fortunately, even some young people like you can act with such conscientiousness... without letting the pulse blind them. And also... in such a traditional manner.”

He paused, then added with a slightly more direct curiosity:

“A hunting crop... A young man of your age who has mastered such an object to this degree. That requires uncommon discipline. I’m delighted that we can remain so traditional... even if it is a little exotic.”

Gold/Richter, embarrassed, tried to change the subject. He picked up the cup again and actually took a sip this time.

“I’m pragmatic and austere, rather than conservative, actually.”

Kurt nodded thoughtfully, almost approvingly, but without seeking to contradict him. He stood up, went to fetch something from a low shelf, then returned with a freshly finished Poké Ball in the palm of his hand. He placed it on the table in front of Gold/Richter.

“So, by way of a modest gesture of compensation... would you like to take this Poké Ball with you?”

Gold/Richter regarded it for a moment. Then he rummaged in the inside pocket of his tailcoat and drew out a small business card. He slid it across the table.

“Yes... Thank you. But by the way...”

He nudged the card slightly towards Kurt.

“I’ll leave this with you. It’s the card of someone who works a lot with Poké Balls. You might find more in common with her than with me.”

Kurt picked up the card between two calloused fingers. He didn’t turn it over straight away. He simply looked at Gold/Richter with an expression that was both serious and slightly proud.

Outside, night had fallen over Azalea. The crackling of the fire seemed louder in the silence that followed.

End of scene

Scene – Two are already rare

Azalea Town Pokémon Centre

The main hall of the Pokémon Centre was almost deserted at this hour. Only two or three travellers were dozing on the benches, and an employee was absent-mindedly tidying away potions behind the counter. The light was low and subdued, and the faint hum of the healing machines barely masked the silence.

Gold/Richter stood in front of one of the public computers, set slightly back in a corner of the room. The screen was lit up with a video call. Chris/Maria appeared on the other end, in what looked like a hostel room. She still had her travelling jacket draped over her shoulders.

‘Oh. So you fought it yourself...?’ she said. Her voice was calm, but there was something slightly sharp in her tone. ‘My congratulations... on your feat.’

Gold/Richter looked down for a moment at the edge of the computer. He clenched his fingers slightly around the metal rim.

“Ah, not quite,” he replied. “I’d checked their levels beforehand. Their Pokémon were still low-level and unevolved. So I initiated the battle straight away. If they’d seemed more capable, I would have acted differently. More carefully.”

Chris/Maria raised an eyebrow, but did not pick up on it straight away. She seemed to be studying his face through the screen.

‘As if you’ve been doing this for ages,’ she murmured. Then, after a short pause: ‘Apart from that... you put my business card to good use.’

Gold/Richter looked up. There was a very brief silence.

“Aren’t you pleased I put you in touch with that craftsman?” he asked. His voice was cautious. “You have things in common, don’t you?”

“Yes,” she conceded. “I do sometimes turn to people like him. But I didn’t recall giving you my cards for that specific purpose.”

Gold/Richter gave an awkward, almost contrite smile.

"Oh. You gave me two... Is that not enough?"

Chris/Maria looked at him for a moment without replying. When she spoke, her voice was lower, almost gentle, but not without a hint of sharpness.

"Consequently... that does rather diminish the value of my business cards, doesn't it? Two was already a rarity."

Gold/Richter looked away slightly. He seemed to be searching for the right words.

"...That wasn't my intention," he said at last. He paused, then added, a little more quickly: "As Professor Elm's assistant, my duties also include collecting combat data. And... putting up with the sarcasm of certain people."

Chris/Maria narrowed her eyes slightly.

"What was that I just heard?"

"Nothing," he replied hastily. "Never mind."

Another silence followed. Chris/Maria was still watching him through the screen; her expression had grown more serious.

"By the way," she continued, "what's with that look on your face? It doesn't really fit with that of someone who's just defeated Team Rocket."

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment; his fingers clenched slightly around the edge of the computer.

BGM: 'Always' 00:00 – 00:28

"...Because I had to give in to blackmail, despite the victory," he said at last. His voice was lower. "...Lance threatened to blow up the device. He'd simply asked me to let them escape; I'd probably have agreed. It was humiliating, but bearable. On the other hand, if he'd demanded that I surrender... I would have resisted. Even under threat. Because that would have been too degrading. Too final."

He looked up at the screen, his expression sombre and puzzled.

"He anticipated that. He chose a threat that left me a way out, whilst forcing me to back down. For someone who's supposed to be nothing more than a thug from a disbanded organisation... it was too precise. Too calculated. As if he knew exactly how far he could push me without me snapping and doing something even worse for him. For a mere criminal... it was too calculated. Too meticulous."

He paused for a moment. The silence on the other side of the screen encouraged him to carry on, almost in spite of himself.

"I don't know if it really was Team Rocket from three years ago," he murmured. "They were less powerful, but that way of operating... that detachment... It doesn't match what I used to know. It's as if they were expecting something from me that I don't yet understand. Or as if I were expecting something from them that was no longer there."

Chris/Maria did not reply straight away; she seemed to be weighing her words.

"...In what context?" she asked at last.

Gold/Richter ran a hand over his face, looking weary.

"I don't know yet," he admitted. "But their arrival in Johto is... unwelcome. And I didn't fight because I really wanted to. I simply had to."

Another silence fell. Then Chris/Maria's tone shifted slightly, becoming lighter, almost teasing, but not entirely without ulterior motive.

"You've just confided in someone whose sarcasm you're supposed to put up with," she said. "What do you mean, if I may ask?"

Gold/Richter looked up at the screen. He seemed to suddenly realise what he'd just done. For a brief moment, he looked flustered.

"Ah..." he simply said.

He looked down at the keyboard, as if searching for a way out.

"We'll meet up in Goldenrod, promise?" he said a little too quickly.

"All right," replied Chris/Maria.

Gold/Richter nodded, already taking a step back.

"It looks as though someone else needs to use this computer. I've kept it for too long. See you later."

He ended the call before she could reply.

On the other side of the screen, Chris/Maria remained motionless for a moment, staring at the frozen image of the disconnected connection. She didn't switch off the monitor straight away. Her fingers remained resting on the edge of the keyboard, without pressing any keys.

Then she murmured, more to herself than to anyone else.

"You insolent wretch..."

She finally pressed the power button. The movement was a little sharper than necessary, but not violent. Just enough to betray an irritation that hadn't quite found a way to express itself.

End of scene

Scene – I don't need weak Pokémon

Azalea Town, in the evening, after the trade with Chris/Maria

The battle had ended in a heavy silence. Silver recalled his last Pokémon with a sharp gesture. He wiped the sweat from his forehead with the back of his hand, then looked up at Gold/Richter.

"Wait... Where's your Cyndaquil?"

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He slowly tucked the empty Poké Ball into his belt. When he finally spoke, his voice was almost too calm.

"With the Professor," said Gold/Richter.

Silver narrowed his eyes.

“...Did you abandon it?”

A joyless smile tugged slightly at Gold/Richter’s lips. He lowered his head for a moment, as if weighing his words.

“This humiliation is unbearable. When my partner is at such a disadvantage that they can’t do anything... I can’t stand it. Not like this.”

Silver fell silent for a moment. Then he let out a short, incredulous laugh.

“Are you joking? You cast him aside because he was losing?”

Gold/Richter looked up. His gaze was sombre, almost weary.

“After your Totodile insulted me simply by existing... I realised just how much I hate this role. The one who has to put up with being oppressed by a stronger partner, simply because he’s the professor’s assistant. Because of that... I’ve come close to bringing you to justice on several occasions. That’s what I found most abhorrent.”

Silver stared at him intently for a long moment. His expression shifted from surprise to something more complex.

“Oh. So you don’t do that anymore?”

Gold/Richter looked away slightly towards the trees lining the field.

“No. Because the situation works in your favour. Professor Elm has suspended the investigation into you.”

The silence that followed was brief, but heavy. Silver narrowed his eyes slightly, as if trying to work out whether it was a joke or a threat.

A phone call, one evening a day ago

Gold/Richter was sitting on the windowsill of his bedroom in Azalea Town. The phone was pressed to his ear. Outside, night had already fallen.

“...What? You’ve suspended the investigation into him?”

On the other end of the line, Professor Elm’s voice was low and embarrassed.

“Quite right.”

BGM: “EP07 S01 17:36–19:00”

Gold/Richter clenched his jaw slightly.

“Why? Because he’s still a child?”

A silence fell.

“...That is not where the problem lies. It is simply... my premonition. This boy is from Kanto. And I would like to understand why he felt the need to steal a Pokémon to begin his journey here. Not just why he stole it. But why he needed it.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment.

"...I know this is a breach of trust for you. To prevent the unfair competition of your predecessors from happening again, I entrusted you with collecting battle data, and Chris/Maria with capturing Pokémon, as my Pokédex assistants. I had hoped that would be enough to break the cycle. But I have failed. Even without a Pokédex, even with only a starter Pokémon... the same pattern is repeating itself."

A long silence followed. Gold/Richter could hear the Professor's laboured breathing.

"...I know I'm putting you in a difficult position, Gold/Richter," said Professor Elm. "I also know that you've already taken on a great deal to apply to become a Pokédex holder. More than most. And I know you've set your Cyndaquil aside so that it wouldn't be part of this... atrocity. I'm sorry about that."

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze to the floor.

"...It's not just that I'll lose with him. It's that I refuse to let him suffer alongside me, as Red had to do for years. Blastoise versus Charizard... that formula is outdated. I do not wish for Cyndaquil to endure the same fate. That is why I set him aside, not because I believed I could prevail without him, but because I refused to make him suffer needlessly."

"...I know." Another silence fell, an even heavier one. "I don't want a young life to be ruined prematurely. That's why I've suspended the investigation. But I have a task for you... if you're willing to accept it. Keep an eye on him. Not like a jailer. Just... watch him. If he ever really hurts you, or if he causes harm to anyone else, I'll reopen the investigation. Without hesitation. But that decision is yours. You're free to refuse."

Gold/Richter remained silent for a long time. All that could be heard was the professor's breathing at the other end of the line.

Then Gold/Richter spoke, in a low, almost weary voice:

"...I accept."

Professor Elm seemed surprised by the speed of the reply.

"...Are you sure? You don't have to, you know."

Gold/Richter kept his eyes fixed on the floor of his bedroom.

"You allowed me to become your assistant... even though you didn't do it just to give me shelter. So I'll do it."

Another silence fell, heavier than before.

"...Gold/Richter..."

"I will watch over him, but do not ask me to bear more than I can."

"...I understand. Thank you. And be careful."

Azalea Town –

Gold/Richter walked over to where Silver had stopped, not far from the edge of the trees.

Silver, clearly waiting, turned when he heard his footsteps.

"You're now under my supervision. I've been given power of attorney by the Professor to report you if you do anything serious," said Gold/Richter.

He paused briefly, then added in a lower voice:

"You've ended up here... in the clutches of Team Rocket? Why is Kanto always teeming with such... phenomenal characters?"

Silver stared at him for a moment. A wry, slightly forced smile slowly spread across his lips. He had picked up on the allusion to his origins, even though Gold/Richter had not mentioned them explicitly.

"Enough of that. If you're complaining about the way things are in Kanto, Kanto doesn't put up with yours either... nor Johto's."

Silver shrugged slightly, as if to brush the subject aside.

"If you need anything..." Gold/Richter offered.

"Let us leave it at that. And besides..." Silver declined.

He turned his head slightly, his tone becoming more brittle again, almost detached:

"I don't need weak Pokémon. There, that's the whole answer. Have a good evening."

Those last words sounded like an excuse. A way of preserving his pride and prestige, rather than a deep-seated conviction. There was a contained tension in his voice, as if uttering that sentence had cost him something.

Without waiting for a reply, Silver strode away towards the forest. He seemed keen to put some distance between himself and this conversation.

Gold/Richter watched him until he disappeared among the trees.

BGM 'EP05 S01 18:34 – 19:24'

It was then that he sensed a presence.

Light. Almost dancing. A subtle rise of a foot off the ground. He turned round slowly.

A woman was standing there, a few metres away. She was wearing traditional attire, simple and elegant. One of the Kimono Girls. She gave off no hostility whatsoever. Just a kind of calm, almost nostalgic curiosity.

'...Who are you?'

The woman tilted her head slightly. Her smile was subtle, enigmatic.

"I wander through this village from time to time. To observe the new generation... and what becomes of them."

She took a graceful, almost imperceptible step to the side. Her gaze lingered for a moment on the spot where Silver had vanished, then returned to Gold/Richter.

"I, too, am a craftswoman... though of a different sort."

She said no more. Nor did she need to.

Gold/Richter then realised that she had heard far more than she let on. Her remark was not merely an introduction. It was a discreet way of letting him know that she had witnessed the previous exchange — and that she had noticed the way Lance had compared himself to Kurt.

The woman continued, in a soft but clear voice:

‘You fought well just now. Against those people in black.’

Her tone was neither approving nor disapproving. Just... matter-of-fact. As if she were assessing something broader than the fight itself.

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He sensed that this woman already knew a great deal that he did not need to explain to her.

The night was mild. And strangely silent.

End of scene

Scene – Jealousy towards ordinary people

Goldenrod City, midday

The semi-covered square near Goldenrod Market was bustling, but not noisy. Daylight filtered through the awnings, casting patches of light onto the cobblestones. Gold/Richter stood slightly apart, his hands in his coat pockets, next to Chris/Maria. Opposite them, the three travelling trainers formed a small, relaxed group: Juggler Mike, who was mechanically rolling a hollow ball between his fingers; Bird Keeper Bryan, whose Pidgey was perched on his shoulder; and Mini Skirt Krise, who was holding her Jigglypuff to her chest like a cushion.

Chris/Maria, arms crossed, watched the trio with an amused but not entirely relaxed half-smile.

‘Say... what made you get into Pokémon, Mike, Bryan, Krise?’

Juggler Mike shrugged slightly. He rolled the hollow ball along his forearm with almost nonchalant precision, then caught it without looking.

“For me, it was down to professional necessity at first. My Pokémon demand a level of discipline from me... that’s almost obsessive. It helps me develop a sense of sobriety.” He gave a slight, wry smile.

“And then, I owe that theatricality in my performances to them. It sometimes makes people smile. I enjoy it, a bit.”

Bird Keeper Bryan nodded. His Pidgey flew down from his shoulder and landed on his outstretched hand. He absent-mindedly stroked the bird’s feathers.

“As for me... I mainly enjoy gazing at the sky in their company. Or at places I couldn’t go on my own. They listen and observe on my behalf. It broadens my horizons. Serious studies are all well and good... but so are things that are a bit more light-hearted. It makes life more bearable.”

Mini Skirt Krise drew her Jigglypuff a little closer. She wore a gentle, almost childlike smile, yet her eyes remained fixed a little too intently upon the ground.

“For me... it’s simpler, I think. I quite like having someone to share everyday life with. Someone who fills the void a bit, when there is one. I hate being alone.” She paused briefly, then added in a quieter voice: “And then... I need them to protect me. I don’t really fancy being attacked by wild Pokémon on my way home.”

A light silence fell, neither awkward nor heavy. Chris/Maria glanced quickly at Gold/Richter. He still hadn’t said a word. He was staring at a vague point between the three Trainers, his eyebrows slightly furrowed, as if he were searching for the right words and couldn’t find them.

“And... have you ever wondered what it would be like if you were to challenge the League? Or even just a few Gyms?” asked Chris/Maria

Juggler Mike let out a small, dry chuckle, without any malice.

“Why the obsession? Not everyone’s cut out for that, you know. Most Trainers don’t have the time, the discipline or the will for spectacular battles.”

Bird Keeper Bryan nodded slowly.

“As for me, I don’t even give it a second thought. Perhaps that fighting spirit... it’s not really part of the culture here in Johto. Not for most of us, anyway. Battling remains a sporting activity, or a daily physical workout.”

Mini Skirt Krise tilted her head slightly, looking genuinely puzzled.

“Why can’t we just... stay like this? With our Pokémon. Without wanting anything more.”

Chris/Maria did not reply straight away. She let the silence hang in the air just long enough for the question to remain unanswered. Then she smiled, a polite but slightly weary smile.

“I expect neither less nor more from you. It’s fine just as it is.” She looked at the three of them, then turned her head slightly towards Gold/Richter, who still hadn’t said a word.

Chris/Maria’s tone changed, becoming more teasing, almost mischievous.

“That said... there’s one of you who’s been silent ever since we started. It’s almost impressive.”

Gold/Richter looked up. He seemed slightly taken aback, but made no attempt to defend himself. He merely shrugged awkwardly.

“...I’m just listening to you, that’s all.”

Juggler Mike regarded him for a moment, then crossed his arms, looking both amused and a little serious.

“By the way... do you really go out of your way to avoid being recognised as Pokédex holders? It seems as though it’s not exactly an honour for you. Especially you, Gold/Richter.”

Gold/Richter lowered his head slightly. He gave a faint smile that did not reach his eyes.

“I prefer to go unnoticed. I don’t want to be seen as... just someone who provides information about battles.” He paused briefly. His voice dropped a notch. “And besides... I don’t really like being compared to my predecessors.”

BGM “EP01 S02 19:53 20:33”

A heavier silence fell. Chris/Maria clenched her jaw discreetly, but said nothing. She cast quick, furtive glances at Gold/Richter, as if to check that he was all right.

Bird Keeper Bryan, feeling a little uncomfortable, tried to steer the conversation back on track:

“What do you mean? Don’t you like them?”

Gold/Richter shook his head slowly.

“It’s not that. I took this job... partly so that other trainers wouldn’t become our victims.” He saw all three faces turn towards him with the same questioning expression. He added, more quietly: “If you know certain stories about them... Never mind.”

Mini Skirt Krise looked at him for a moment, then turned to Chris/Maria with a gentle but direct curiosity.

“Chris/Maria... has Gold/Richter always been like this, even before?”

Chris/Maria opened her mouth, then closed it again. She cast a quick glance at Gold/Richter, who had frozen slightly. She smiled, but her smile was a little too controlled.

“Oh... about that...” She paused deliberately, then shook her head lightly. “It’s best not to dig into it. It’s an old story.”

Gold/Richter relaxed imperceptibly. He looked down at the floor, then raised his head towards the three trainers. His voice was a little lower, almost awkward.

“Sorry. There are some people... I’m not very good at dealing with them. I’m sometimes afraid of saying things that sound... hollow, or condescending. I changed quite a bit before I set off on my journey. I was afraid people wouldn’t adapt to my way of doing things.”

Mini Skirt Krise regarded him for a long moment, then smiled kindly. She hugged her Jigglypuff a little tighter.

“You could try to relax a bit.” Mini Skirt Krise tilted her head slightly. “You’re special, it’s true. But being special doesn’t necessarily mean you’re weird. You’re still... one of us. We’re happy to listen to you. Really.”

BGM ‘Dido’s Lament’ 01:22–the end

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment. He looked down at his shoes, then back up at her. His voice was softer, almost weary, but sincere.

“...Thank you. I don’t think I would have flourished anywhere other than in Johto. That’s what I’ve come to realise during this journey. I’m grateful for that.”

A silence fell. This time, it was neither heavy nor awkward. Just... there.

Juggler Mike finally broke the silence in a slightly lower voice, almost as if to himself:

‘...I’ve heard that one of your predecessors used to take out his Pokédex quite often, and the other hardly ever. That sort of thing is rare.’

Gold/Richter looked up. He glanced at the three Trainers one by one, then lowered his voice slightly.

“We gather information first. And we fight fairly, depending on your circumstances. We’re not exempt from developing our own battle intuition.”

Bird Keeper Bryan regarded him with even greater curiosity.

“Is that restraint? Or sobriety?”

Gold/Richter shook his head slowly.

“Neither. Even some Trainers without a Pokédex, without sophisticated breeding programmes... they have a certain dignity. They face what they lack, and they grow. That’s all this journey has taught me.” He paused, then added more softly: “Like you, Mike, you’ve taken on a responsibility similar to mine. Bryan, your condition doesn’t stop you from exploring. And Krise... you’re content just to stay with your Pokémon. These are qualities that even some experts struggle to maintain: being content without always wanting more.”

The silence that followed was longer than the previous ones. The three Trainers looked at him, not quite sure how to respond. It wasn’t awkwardness. It was something else — as if Gold/Richter had said something too heavy for the moment, yet no one wanted to hold it against him.

Juggler Mike finally shrugged slightly, with a faint, wry smile, as if to lighten the mood.

‘...That said, I know quite a few people who are far more ambitious than you... even with even fewer resources.’

Bird Keeper Bryan nodded slowly.

“Such modesty at your age... it’s rare. But not entirely unfounded.”

Mini Skirt Krise looked at them both, then turned her attention back to Chris/Maria and Gold/Richter. She hesitated for a moment, then asked the question in a softer, almost shy voice:

“By the way... if it’s not too personal...” She looked from one to the other. “Are you... brother and sister?”

Chris/Maria and Gold/Richter froze at the same time. A faint blush crept onto both their cheeks, though they could not bring themselves to look at one another.

“...Yes. But... where did you get that idea from?” replied Gold/Richter.

Mini Skirt Krise tilted her head slightly, looking genuinely puzzled.

“Because you don’t look like you’re just friends. Or a couple. And for colleagues... you’re a bit too direct and close. But there are still limits. Like... a sort of distance you keep.”

Chris/Maria crossed her arms, looking both amused and a little embarrassed. She tried to brush the question aside with a light-hearted tone.

“A keen eye can be useful.”

End of scene

Scene – The Hidden Siblings

On the way to Goldenrod City *Dusk is falling. The path is lined with trees whose leaves are beginning to turn yellow. The wind occasionally whips up small gusts of dust and dead leaves.*

BGM “EP01 S01 16:46–17:00”

Chris/Maria and Gold/Richter walked side by side, keeping a distance that was neither too close nor too far. Behind them, the three travelling Trainers had already moved on. They’d exchanged only brief waves as they parted ways.

Gold/Richter kept his eyes fixed on the ground ahead of him. Chris/Maria, for her part, observed her companion’s profile out of the corner of her eye. They walked on in silence for a while. Chris/Maria finally broke the silence, in a drawling voice:

‘Are you aware that your demand was rather tactless?’

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly, looking lost.

“What did I demand of you?”

She let out a small, dry laugh.

“You agreed that I could take the Pokédex... on condition that I dressed ‘more appropriately’. To criticise a young girl for her choice of clothing... How presumptuous.”

He lowered his gaze to the path. His fingers tightened around the strap of his bag.

“I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to... It’s just that my clothes couldn’t possibly look like yours.”

Chris/Maria looked at him askance.

“Oh. Your strategy. The sibling camouflage.”

He did not reply straight away. His lips parted slightly, then closed again. He finally nodded, just once, half-heartedly.

“It’s working very well, isn’t it? Hardly anyone suspects us.”

“As if it were your wish for us to be reduced to siblings,” she retorted. “And as if it came at no cost.”

The silence that followed was even heavier. Gold/Richter kept his eyes fixed on the floor. Chris/Maria made no attempt to break it.

After a moment, she continued, in a slightly lighter tone.

‘You still tie your bow tie by hand every day, even here.’

He slowed down slightly. His fingers instinctively brushed against the bow tie at his throat, as if to make sure it was still securely in place.

‘...Why ask that now?’

“Most boys your age wouldn’t care. How did you learn to tie it?”

“The instructions are on the internet,” he replied after a moment. “It’s just a matter of diligence and perseverance.”

Chris/Maria let her gaze wander over him: the ponytail, the hunting crop, the cufflinks.

"A Victorian hunting crop, a tailcoat, cufflinks... It's all so old-fashioned. Do you have a walking stick as well?"

"At my hotel."

She gave a half-hearted smile.

"On that note, I'd bet you've got a top hat as well..."

He turned his head slightly away.

"...Yes. But I rarely wear it."

Chris/Maria fell silent for a moment. When she spoke again, her voice had lost some of its edge.

"You know it's become harder to be part of your circle..."

Gold/Richter clenched his jaw. He'd realised what she was getting at.

"If you're implying that I sometimes express myself too philosophically... I'll admit it."

"No," she murmured. "What I'm getting at is, as your colleague—or someone closer to you than they are... You know... your outfit doesn't always really hide the shape of your body."

He blushed fiercely and unwittingly quickened his pace. Chris/Maria caught up with him without commenting on his reaction.

After a few seconds, he finally replied, in a low voice.

"If you're talking about my change... in clothing, it's partly because of my body. I'm not that narcissistic. I want people to pay attention to my discipline, to my progress... rather than my appearance."

Chris/Maria regarded him for a long time.

"Was that exactly why you've been training? Is it so you can use the hunting crop?"

He paused for a moment. The wind ruffled the strands of hair that had escaped from his ponytail.

"Yes. I chose this instrument. It is less violent, harder to use... but more legitimate, at least than firearms. It demands more discipline from me."

Chris/Maria let out a little sigh.

'Coming from you, "discipline" sounds more like self-flagellation... It is absurd that someone who dresses like that is so clumsy around their peers.'

Gold/Richter lowered his head. His voice was deeper as he replied.

"Chris/Maria... after all these years, I've faced the consequences of my decisions. I'm trying to make things right... but I can't always put things back exactly as they were. I'm sorry."

BGM: 'Too Heavy'

She said nothing. The silence lasted for several steps.

Gold/Richter continued, more quietly.

"I've set out on this journey, not out of complacency, but to find *an alexipharmic* to the disasters caused by our predecessors. We're not from the same branch as Professor Oak. So if my Pokémon aren't enough... I might have to fight myself. The mutation of that era."

Chris/Maria regarded him askance.

"Apart from your clumsiness, you've still got something of what you used to have. That tendency to push yourself too hard. Does that caution still cost you as much?"

He nodded slowly.

"I deserve your scorn."

They walked on in silence for a while longer. The first lights of Goldenrod were appearing in the distance.

Chris/Maria finally broke the silence in a softer voice.

"As Krise said... you could try to relax a bit. There's no need to be so philosophical."

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly towards her.

"It wasn't some high-minded philosophy... Do you remember the Team Rocket executive I was telling you about?"

"Lance?"

"Exactly. I gradually realised why he unsettled me so much... At that moment, he just stood there, constantly watching us... Our Pokémon weren't exceptional, whereas his excelled intellectually, and in an asymmetrical way. His... more predatory... ancient. Still indecipherable to me. And his aim was to bide his time, to overwhelm the others at the right moment. Some of our behaviours are similar, even if our motives differ."

He stopped walking. Chris/Maria stopped too.

"If the people here had not been as tolerant, as unconventional as Krise, Mike and Bryan... I would have been seen as a villain like Lance. Even though it was not my fault," he said.

His voice dropped even further:

"If you keep highlighting my clumsiness... you know better than anyone how even unfounded criticism can break and frustrate exceptional people. I'm not saying I'm one of them. But you know my vulnerability better than anyone else."

He drew a breath.

"Krise comforted me... but above all, she showed me that she could tell right from wrong. That encouraged me. I can set out in search of my own horizons, because the people of Johto tolerate me and shelter me. I depend on them. And for that, I'm grateful to have been born here."

Chris/Maria looked at him for a long time. Her features had softened.

"Last time, I didn't have enough opportunity to talk to you, or to observe you. Now... I can at least ease my conscience a little. You've changed, but not for the worse."

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes. His voice was almost a whisper:

“Thank you for your kindness... Ah, by the way... Could you please not reveal our past to the others? Please.”

It was the first time he had really looked at her since they had started walking.

Chris/Maria held his gaze for a moment, then nodded.

“No problem. If I gave too much of what you’ve confided in me away, you wouldn’t be able to open up to anyone.”

They continued walking in silence, as the first houses of Goldenrod came into view.

End of scene

Scene – The Primitive Urge

Street in Goldenrod City (in front of the shop windows)

The programme continues on the screens. The reporter speaks with restrained tension, but his gaze keeps drifting towards the darkness behind him. Behind the bushes and trees, a dark shape moves.

The image changes. A closer shot lingers on an **Arbok**.

BGM ‘EP03 S02 05:00 05:40’

It does not move with the haste of a stressed or enraged Pokémon. It glides with an almost solemn slowness, its body undulating silently across the ground. Its dark scales absorb the light rather than reflect it. From time to time, its tongue flickers out, not to sniff, but as if to taste the air itself. There is something ancient and patient about its movement, as if it were performing an action it had already performed long before humans built cities and roads.

Gold/Richter, standing before the display case, feels a cold shiver run down his spine. It is not rage. It is not even ordinary savagery. It is something colder, more impersonal. As if this creature were hunting not merely to feed itself, but to remind us that certain laws had never truly disappeared.

The Arbok stops.

Then it **lunges**.

The image explodes in a brutal, heavy movement. The Arbok crashes down on the cameraman with terrifying force. No roar. Just a dull thud, followed by the muffled sound of the coils instantly wrapping themselves around the body. The Arbok does not bite to kill. It **constricts**. Its coils tighten with a methodical, almost ritualistic slowness. We cannot see the cameraman’s face. We see only his body deforming under the pressure, and the Arbok holding its grip without haste, as if it had all the time in the world.

The image shakes violently. The journalist steps back, breathless. The Arbok raises its head slightly whilst holding its prey, and for a moment, its eyes meet the rolling camera. They do not gleam with hatred or triumph. They are almost empty, glassy, like those of a creature that existed long before cities, before roads, before the men who film.

The Arbok tightens its grip one last time. A final crack rings out, clearer than the others.

Then the image cuts to black.

BGM effect 'Eclipse' 03:04–03:06

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

Scenes: 12 · Words: $\approx$ 14,400 · Read aloud: $\approx$ 95 min · 34 pp. A4.

Still an arc compilation (nocturnal Kanto + Johto threshold).

Version notes

2026-09-23 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Manuscript notes moved to the sheet. EN anchors. JP table for Krise / Bryan / Mike and the two Lances. Respective compassion (not Mutual).

Open for what follows

Dark outline · Houndoom · Arbok at Goldenrod · unrevealed past · Lance–Rocket.

BGM credits

Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix). Eclipse = effect. Traces $\neq$ titles